

Someone's coming over and your place is a disaster.

Six things, in this order. About thirty-five minutes if you have it, and it still works if you don't.

Do them in order and stop when they knock. The order runs biggest visible difference first, so wherever you get to is the right place to have stopped. You are not going to finish and you don't need to.

Nothing to sign up for. Start at one.

1 Bin out. Window open.

3 min

Take the kitchen trash **all the way out** — not into the hallway. Fresh bag in. Then open a window in the room they'll sit in and leave it open while you do everything else.

Why this is first. Smell is what people register before they register anything they can see, and they will never mention it. The trash is usually the reason. Five minutes of open window does more than anything you can spray. If you want the place to smell of something afterwards, that's fine — just do it once the source is gone, rather than over the top of it.

2 Empty the sink.

5 min

Everything in it goes in the dishwasher, or gets washed and left on the rack. Then wipe the counter it was sitting on. **Completely empty** — not tidier.

Why it's worth five minutes. An empty sink makes a kitchen read as clean even if you touch nothing else. A full one reads as chaos even when everything around it is spotless. It's the single most unfair detail in the house, and it's free.

3 One basket. Clear every flat surface.

10 min

Get a laundry basket or a cardboard box. Walk the room they'll be in and put **everything that doesn't live there** into it — coffee table, dining table, the arm of the chair, the floor, the back of the sofa. Then put the basket in your bedroom and shut the door.

This is a trick and you're going to have to deal with it. Worth being straight about that. But it takes ten minutes instead of two hours, and it is the biggest visual change available to you today. There's a note at the bottom about why that basket filled up, which is the part that actually matters.

4 The bathroom, properly.

8 min

They will go in there alone and they will look. In order: **toilet** — bowl, seat, and the rim underneath it — then **sink**, then **mirror**, then the floor immediately around the toilet. Put out a clean towel. Empty the trash.

This is the one room worth doing properly. It's the only space a guest occupies by themselves with nothing to do but look around. Everywhere else you're standing next to them, talking, and they're not inspecting anything.

5 The floor they'll walk on.

5 min

The way in, and the room they'll sit in. Whatever you've got — vacuum, broom, or a damp cloth over the obvious bits. **That's the whole job.**

Not the rest of it. Nobody is looking at the floor of a room they never enter. Doing the hallway and the living room properly beats doing the whole place badly, and it takes a fifth of the time.

6 Turn the big light off.

2 min

Lamps on instead. No lamps? Turn off half the overhead lights, or all of them in the rooms you're not using.

Thirty seconds, and it changes the room more than the last twenty minutes did. Low, warm light from a couple of low points is forgiving about everything you didn't get to, and it reads as a deliberate choice rather than a rescue. This is the step people skip and then wonder why the place still feels off.

ONE SAFETY THING

Don't mix cleaning products while you're rushing.

Bleach with ammonia — which is in a lot of glass cleaners — or **bleach with vinegar** makes genuinely dangerous fumes in a small bathroom.

One product at a time, and you're fine.

When they knock, you're done.

Whatever you got through is what there was time for. The list is ordered so that stopping early still leaves you better off than any other order would have — that's the entire point of the order.

Don't apologize for the place when they walk in. They weren't going to notice, and saying it out loud is what makes them look.

About that basket.

Tomorrow you'll find a laundry basket of unrelated objects in your bedroom, and you'll put most of it back exactly where it was. That's not a discipline problem.

Almost everything in that basket has nowhere to live. That's the real reason the surfaces fill up, and it's why this happens again in three weeks. Not laziness — an unmade decision, repeated daily. You can't tidy your way out of it, which is why tidying never worked.

| *"Everything has it's place. Do it now."*

Those are Dave's. He's a real person, he's been saying them for decades, and he taught me how to run a house after I'd spent years failing at it. He's faintly embarrassed to tell anyone any of this, because he assumes everybody already knows. Almost nobody does. Nobody teaches it.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

That was crisis cleaning.

Dave's rule is **preventative cleaning rather than crisis cleaning** — and tonight was the crisis version. It works. You'll also need it again.

Needing it again is the actual problem. Not tonight, and not the state of the place. The reason tonight was necessary at all.